‘Must be an organizational requirement,’ Maa added as we walked inside. ‘It has happened many times in the past with your father.’

Even though I didn’t take it well, my parents seemed quite okay with it. They had seen military life more than I had and were accustomed to such recall letters. It obviously saddened me and I didn’t want to go.

‘You must freshen up and eat your food,’ Papaji said. ‘In the meantime, I’ll go to the Movement Control Office (MCO) at the railway station and book a ticket for you. There’s a direct train from Lucknow to Jammu.’

I spent the next few hours at home until my parents dropped me off at the railway station in the evening. Papaji asked me not to remain sad about my recall and reminded me that my duty was priority. I reached my mess at Udhampur the next evening and reported to my flight commander. He told me to meet him in the office the next morning. I remember listening to a news report that evening that said that Pakistan had started shelling NH-1, which connected Srinagar to Ladakh. It was during the next morning’s briefing that I finally understood how vast the scale of this operation was. The Indian Air Force had launched Operation Safed Sagar, which was the code name assigned to the IAF’s efforts to flush out Pakistani infiltrators. By the end of the first week of June, the Indian Army had recovered documents from Pakistani soldiers that proved the Pakistan Army’s involvement in these infiltrations in the guise of the mujahideen. By then, my CO had already passed orders to me—I was to fly a sortie to Srinagar.

‘I cannot tell you how long you will have to stay in Srinagar, but be prepared,’ he said to me that evening. This was when I realized that once I had reached Srinagar, I might not be able to speak to my parents for a long time. The first thing I did after getting the order to fly to Srinagar was ring up my parents in Lucknow from an STD booth. All I said to my parents was that I was going for some routine sorties. They asked me to take care of myself. They were undoubtedly worried, since both their children would be in the combat zone, and things were only getting worse along the LoC.

I left for Srinagar the very next day. I didn’t think too much about the whole situation. To me, it was just a normal sortie, since I was accustomed to flying to the Srinagar airbase frequently. The terrain was etched in my